

ASSERTION OF THE UNDERDOG

Grassroots leaders with a mass base are challenging the ways of the central high command in a party that was once known for its cadre discipline and internal democracy

■ By Priya Sahgal and Aditi Pai

It was a defiant leap forward for a backward leader in a party known for its higher caste leadership. When BJP General Secretary Gopinath Munde revolted, few expected that the rebel would prevail and the high command would give in. The central leadership that okayed the appointment of the Maharashtra veteran's rival Madhu Chavan as chief of the party's Mumbai unit was in for a

rude shock when Munde got the support of over 65 legislators and 11 of the 12 MPs from the state threatened to resign. Munde was summoned to Delhi, not for a reprimand but to be mollified. Within hours of his meeting with party supremo L.K. Advani and party President Rajnath Singh, Chavan was replaced by an old Pramod Mahajan loyalist, Gopal Shetty. Suddenly, the party grandees ensconced in Lutyens' bungalows realised the veto power of those who rule the grassroots.

Maharashtra may be a story of the rebel who has won, but it's not the only story of infighting in a party that was once famous for its discipline and inner-party democracy. Come to Bihar. In the recent cabinet reshuffle, Ashwini Kumar Choubey was shifted from Urban Development to Public Health Engineering Department and two other upper caste leaders were dropped. The high command saw it as a whim of Deputy Chief Minister Sushil Modi, an OBC leader and the party's most popular face in the state. What made it worse for Modi was the central leadership's claim that he had misled them about the reshuffle. Now, Choubey has provoked as many as 40 of the 55 MLAs to demand Modi's ouster.

In the south, the party is fighting two battles: one for the state of Karnataka and one within. Popular Lingayat leader B.S. Yeddyurappa, a grassroots politician, is not the favourite of the party's Delhi durbar,

MENDING FENCES: (L-R) Gadkari, Rajnath, Naidu and Munde in Delhi

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